Monkeys

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Mammalia
ORDER	Primates
SUBORDER	Haplorrhini (part)
FAMILIES	6
SPECIES	315

This large, diverse group is split into 2 broad, geographically separate subgroups: the Old World monkeys (larger species such as baboons, as well as colobus monkeys and langurs) and the New World monkeys (such as marmosets and spider monkeys), which are distinguished mainly by nose shape. Monkeys are normally found in forests throughout the tropics. Most have short, flat, humanlike faces, although baboons and mandrills have a doglike snout. Many species are endangered by loss of habitat, and the rhesus macaque is one example of a monkey used widely in laboratory research.

Anatomy

Monkeys are characterized by a flattened chest, a hairy nose, a relatively large brain, a deep lower jaw, and sharp canine teeth. Although monkeys are quadrupedal, they are able to sit upright (and will occasionally stand erect), so that the dextrous hands are freed for manipulative tasks (such as picking apart fruit). They have grasping hands and feet, each with 5 digits. Their legs are slightly longer than the arms—much longer in leaping species (such as the red colobus), which also have a long, flexible spine. Monkeys also have a tail that is usually longer than the body, although in some species it is tiny and underdeveloped. A few New World species, such as spider monkeys, have a prehensile tail, sometimes with a bare area at the end with creases and ridges that increase friction for grasping. The tail may be used as a balancing organ and to indicate social gestures.

There are several anatomical differences between Old and New World monkeys. Old World monkeys, which are more closely related to apes than the New World monkeys, have a narrow nasal septum and the nostrils face forward or downward. New World monkeys have a broad nasal septum and nostrils that face sideways. Another major difference is that Old World monkeys have hard sitting pads on the rump, which are absent in New World monkeys.

Social groups

New World monkeys have a great variety of social organizations. Marmosets, for example, usually live in groups consisting of a monogamous pair and subadult offspring that help rear the recent young. Squirrel monkeys, on the other hand, live in very large groups, sometimes over 100, with many females and few males. Spider monkeys live in large communities that split into small groups of varying composition when foraging.

In contrast, Old World monkeys usually exhibit just 2 types of social organization: savanna baboons and macaques live in large, multi-male troops; Hamadryas baboons, geladas, and langurs live in "harems," with one adult male and several females. Within all monkey social groups, relationships are commonly very close, and grooming is a significant social glue. However, males in some species, such as baboons, will fight furiously with their long, sharp canines for dominance.

Intelligence

Monkeys are intelligent mammals. They are quick to learn, inquisitive, and have an excellent memory. These abilities have helped monkeys succeed in a range of habitats, where they must learn (for example) what they can eat and then remember when and where to find the food again.

AGILE CLIMBER
All monkeys are excellent climbers. This woolly spider monkey has a long prehensile tail, which acts as a "fifth limb" when moving along or resting on branches. The tail has an end section with a naked underside (used to aid grasping) and is strong enough to support both the monkey and its offspring.